

CORE FORMULA

Notice the shift -> ask one low-pressure follow-up -> watch for confirmation -> follow or release. -> You seemed a bit more interested when you mentioned that — want to go there for a second? -> That part seems most relevant. Should we focus there? -> You had more to say about that part — want to stay with it, or go another direction? -> We don't have to stay on that. What part is actually worth focusing on?

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Notice which topic draws more detail, warmth, or speed, then offer one light follow-up with an easy way out: "You had more to say about that part — want to stay with it, or go another direction?"

BEST FOR

- First conversations and warm openings
- Networking without interrogating
- Dating and friendship conversations
- Mentoring and one-to-ones
- Team meetings with several competing threads
- Interviews and discovery conversations
- Family catch-ups and any chat with multiple possible threads

PHRASE BANK

Ultra-light · One-line tests

- "More in that?"
- "Stay there or move on?"
- "What's the interesting bit?"
- "Want to go there for a second?"
- "Say more about that part?"
- "That one seems to have more in it."
- "Worth staying with?"

Social & rapport · Warm follow-ups

- "You gave more detail there — what makes that part interesting?"
- "That bit seemed to have more life in it. Want to stay there?"
- "That sounds like the part you actually enjoy — what's good about it?"
- "You had more to say about that. I'd genuinely like to hear it."
- "There was more energy around that one. What draws you to it?"
- "That seems like the thread worth following. Tell me more?"
- "You seemed a bit more interested when you mentioned that — want to go there for a second?"

Work & meetings · Focus and relevance

- "That part seems most relevant. Should we focus there?"
- "You had more specifics around that. Is that the main thread?"
- "That's where the detail is. Want to build on it?"
- "Sounds like the live issue is that one. Shall we start there?"
- "You went into more depth on that. Is that the priority?"
- "That seems like the thread with the most in it. Should we dig in?"

- "Happy to go wherever's useful — that looks like the stronger thread."

Choice & direction · Two-option questions

- "Is that the useful thread, or is there somewhere better to go?"
- "Want to focus on this or that — or something else?"
- "Stay with this, or would another angle be more useful?"
- "Is that the main thread, or a side one?"
- "Should we go deeper on that, or move on?"
- "What's actually worth focusing on here?"
- "Where would you rather take this?"

Sensitive & conflict-safe · Tentative and correctable

- "I may be reading this wrong, but that seems to matter more than the rest."
- "We do not have to stay on that. What part is actually worth focusing on?"
- "We do not have to solve everything. What's worth focusing on first?"
- "Tell me if I've got the wrong end of this."
- "No pressure either way — just checking where the real thread is."
- "That might not be the point at all. What is, for you?"
- "I don't want to push it if that's not where you want to go."

Recovery & release · Repair a missed read

- "I may be reading that wrong."
- "No need to go there if that's not the thread."
- "We can leave that."
- "I don't want to over-focus on it."
- "What direction would you rather take this?"
- "What part of this is actually useful to talk about?"
- "Fair enough — let's move on."

Digital / text · Message-length

- "That point sounds like the live one. Want to unpack it?"
- "That seems to be the stronger thread — happy to go there."
- "Sounds like there's more in that part. Say more?"
- "Want to focus on the first thing or the second?"
- "That one reads like the interesting bit. Up to you though."
- "I'll follow whichever's more useful — that one, maybe?"
- "No rush — which part's worth getting into?"

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: "You lit up when you said that." Naming a hidden feeling can sound intrusive or performative, especially if repeated.
Better: "You had more to say about that part." This anchors the read in observable detail, not their inner state.
Best: "You had more to say about that part — want to stay with it, or go another direction?" Observation, invitation, and an easy exit.
2. Weak: "What team? Why? What happened?" A stack of questions aimed at whichever detail you noticed first.
Better: One follow-up about the topic that actually gained detail.
Best: One follow-up about the livelier topic, with room to decline: "?or we can leave it there."
3. Weak: Keep pulling them back to the topic you find interesting.
Better: Notice they answered briefly and stop pushing.
Best: Offer the choice openly: "Stay with this, or is there somewhere more useful to go?"

DECISION TREE

If Energy rises on a topic

Ask one small follow-up and watch whether they add more.
"You had more to say about that — want to stay with it?"

If Energy drops

Reduce pressure; offer a pivot or ask what's more useful to focus on.

"We don't have to stay on that. What's actually worth focusing on?"

If Energy shifts to a new topic

Follow the new thread; don't drag your old question back.

"That seems like the livelier bit now — shall we go there?"

If You're unsure which thread has energy

Ask a choice-based question instead of guessing.

"Is that the useful thread, or is there somewhere better to go?"

If The topic is sensitive

Don't name the energy; use choice and permission instead.

"No pressure — where would you rather take this?"

If Your read missed

Release and hand control back.

"I may be reading that wrong. What part's actually useful to talk about?"

SCENARIOS

Networking

They mention several projects — follow the one they describe with more specificity and examples. — "You went into more detail on the second one — is that the project you're most into?"

Team meeting

Discussion is broad — listen for the issue that creates detail and forward motion, then propose focus. — "The rollout point seems to have the most in it. Should we start there?"

Mentoring

A mentee lists problems — follow the one with ownership and examples, not the loudest complaint. — "You had the most to say about the client work. Want to dig into that one?"

Social conversation

They briefly brighten around a hobby or place — test it lightly and leave room to decline. — "That trip sounds like the good bit — want to tell me about it, or move on?"

Digital message

The message has several topics — reflect the likely live thread and offer a small choice. — "Sounds like the new role is the big thing — want to focus on that, or the move first?"

Sensitive topic

A topic has energy but might be risky — use choice and permission, don't name the energy. — "We don't have to get into that. Where would you rather take it?"

WHEN NOT TO USE

- There is a real power imbalance and the person may feel evaluated
- Someone is in distress or under time pressure
- You need specific information and they are giving short necessary answers
- The setting is clinically or professionally sensitive
- A topic has energy only because it is risky, not because it should be explored
- You are tempted to use it to sell, seduce, extract, or manoeuvre
- They have given a direct answer or boundary — that beats your read

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Spot the energy

Watch a short interview or podcast. Every 60 seconds, note which topic drew more detail, warmth, speed, or examples.

Day 2 — Name the cue

Recall three conversations from today and write down the exact observable cue that told you energy rose or dropped — not what you assumed they felt.

Day 3 — Rewrite the question

Take five interrogative questions and rewrite each as one observation plus one low-pressure invitation with an escape hatch.

Day 4 — One silent use

In a real conversation, track energy silently: choose your next question based on the livelier topic without naming your read.

Day 5 — One light test

Use one named observation-plus-invitation, once. The goal isn't to impress — notice whether that single light follow-up increases ease.

Day 6 — Practise the release

Deliberately let a low-energy thread go. The moment a topic flattens, say a pivot line aloud and move on without pushing.

Day 7 — Recovery reps

Rehearse aloud: "I may be reading that wrong," "We can leave that," "What direction would you rather take this?" Then use one in a live conversation.

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I read energy from observable cues, not assumption?
- Did I use one light follow-up rather than a chain of questions?
- Did I leave an easy way to decline or redirect?
- Did I avoid probing anything sensitive the person didn't lead into?
- Did the person add more after my move — or did I keep pushing anyway?
- Did I release when the energy didn't increase?